

Negative Announcement: Ybarra Dental Group

You are the part-time receptionist for the Ybarra Dental Group. Your office has a “three strikes” policy regarding appointments: if a patient breaks three appointments within 18 months and without advance notice, that patient is not allowed to make any further appointments with the dental group.

The office has adopted this policy for several reasons, not least of which is that it takes dentists and dental hygienists approximately 30 minutes to prepare for each appointment.

Jeff Troxel has just missed his third appointment in 18 months, including a minor surgical procedure. After each incident, he has rescheduled and apologized, but has offered no explanation for the missed appointments. The lead dentist, Dr. Ybarra, has asked you to write a letter informing him that he will need to find a new dentist. She plans on using this letter as a template for future patients who flaunt the missed appointment rule.

In order to develop enough specific content for the letter, you’ll need to think carefully about the reasons you’ll use to justify the office’s position. (Come up with more of these on your own.) You’ll also need to do what you can to maintain Jeff’s goodwill. True, you will never see him again, but you want to avoid alienating his family and friends, some of whom are patients at your office.

Guidelines

As you draft the letter to Mr. Troxel, make sure you

- review the Bad-News Assignment Description
- use the appropriate approach (direct or indirect)
- make up (brainstorm) more reasons (facts) for the office’s appointment policy and present those objectively
- offer some positive news related to his situation
- close the letter using a forward-looking tone

Resources

Review specific negative message types throughout Rentz chapter 6, but focus on Learning Outcome 6-6 (pp. 148-54), including all sample messages presented and discussed under that outcome.

Contact Information

Use these addresses in your letter:

Denise Ybarra, DDS
Ybarra Dental Group
2348 West Palmetto Canyon Drive
Suite A
La Mesa, CA 92119

Jeff Troxel
4156 Alabama Street
San Diego, CA 92104